



BEFORE

Historic distrust and ideological differences between the Soviet Union and the United States led to tension in the wartime alliance.

US IN SIBERIA

Antagonism between the Soviet Union and the US began in the **Russian Civil War** << 377 when the US intervened in Siberia (northeast Russia). Between 1918 and 1920, US troops fought on the side of the White Army against the Bolsheviks. Although the US later sent aid to the fledgling Soviet state, diplomatic relations were not in place until 1933.



US TROOPS IN SIBERIA

CLASH OF IDEALS

Even as their wartime alliance defeated **Nazi Germany** << 392–97, relations cooled between the Soviet Union and the Western powers. In the US there was unease about the rise of European communism << 335, an ideology that advocated worldwide revolution and the end of capitalism. The West, led by the US, was equally mistrusted by the Soviet Union.



COMMUNIST POSTER

Berlin Airlift

Berlin's children greet one of the British and American transport planes that flew a total of 2.3 million tons of food, medicines, and fuel into their beleaguered city in 1948 and 1949.

The Cold War

After World War II global politics became polarized as countries around the world allied themselves with either the United States or the Soviet Union. The East–West divide between communism and capitalism dominated world events for the next 40 years.

When the Allied powers met at Yalta and Potsdam to shape postwar Europe (see p.397), Stalin's insistence that Soviet borders be extended to cover eastern Poland and the Baltic states raised anxieties about his expansionist ambitions. Between 1945–47, the Soviets gained in influence as communist governments were founded in other Eastern European states (jointly known as the Eastern Bloc). With Britain's status as a world power damaged by six years of war, it became clear that the only Western power with comparable strength to the Soviet Union was the United States. In 1947 the British prime minister, Winston Churchill, had to request US support in Greece, where a civil war was raging between the royalist government and communist

partisans. The request prompted US President Truman to pledge assistance to all states trying to defend democracy against external threat. This became known as "The Truman Doctrine." Truman argued that the spread of communist regimes must be combated or America's national security would be at risk. This marked a new phase in US foreign policy called "containment." Over the next few years, through measures such as the Marshall Plan (see p.452), the US poured millions of dollars in financial and military aid into non-communist European states, bolstering their economic recoveries. The Soviet Union saw US containment measures

as imperialist and aggressive. It reacted by strengthening its own power base. In 1947 Andrei Zhdanov, a senior Soviet official, stated that the world was split into two camps: Western imperialists and socialist anti-imperialists. He set up the Cominform, an organization that supervised the strict ideological conformity of Eastern Bloc regimes with Moscow's party line. The first confrontation of the Cold War occurred in Berlin.



Korean War propaganda

The Korean communists produced anti-capitalist propaganda, such as this poster. It aims to demoralize US troops, stating they will die for capitalist greed.

